

**How does vehicle
dominance
change?**



**Centre for Blockchain
Technologies**

Vehicle Currency Rotation in Decentralised Exchanges

Evidence from Ethereum routes
Jiahua Xu

The PYUSD swap reaches a USDC-funded pool route

USER INSTRUCTION RECORDED BY THE EXPLORER

Transaction details # 0x

⚡ Swap 460.00K  PYUSD for 460.10K  USDE on 0x  0x

THE DECISIVE SETTLEMENT TRANSFERS

 USDC
ERC-20 **Transfer**

📄 Market Maker: 0x51c7..... → 📄 Mainnetsettler 📄

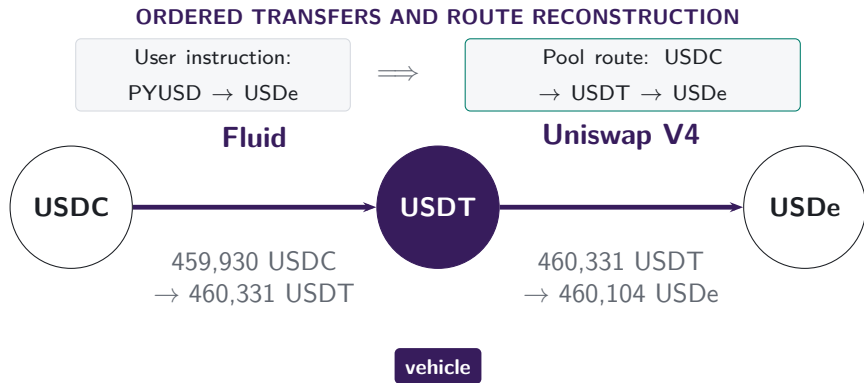
 USDC
ERC-20 **Transfer**

📄 Mainnetsettler 📄 → 📄 Fluid: Liquidity 📄

The instruction is PYUSD → USDe. The maker supplies the USDC used by the Fluid leg, which begins the connected pool route.

Note: The explorer screenshot and transfer trace refer to transaction 0xbda1d07f...9bf67ad9 on 10 January 2026.

Inside the pools, USDT links USDC to USDe



Our route sample begins with USDC, the source asset of the connected pool-swap component. USDT is the vehicle because it links the two legs.

Note: The route is the connected pool-swap component of transaction 0xbda1d07f...9bf67ad9 on 10 January 2026.

Vehicle dominance is the share of indirect trade carried by an asset

MEASUREMENT

- Dominance is the share of indirect trade intermediated by asset k .
- Count share treats each route equally; value share weights routes by dollar value.
- Network measures capture how broadly k connects endpoint pairs.



Count-weighted dominance

Share of indirect routes that pass through k

Value-weighted dominance

Share of comparable routed value that passes through k

Architecture changes routing opportunities

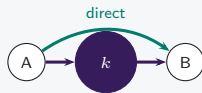
V1 mandatory hub



Only ETH-token pools: token-to-token execution must pass through ETH.

Hub use is imposed

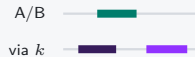
V2 pair choice



Arbitrary pairs add a direct route; vehicle routes remain feasible.

Hub use becomes a choice

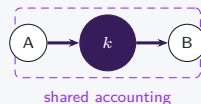
V3 range choice



LPs choose ranges and fees; active depth can favor direct pairs or vehicle spokes.

Opportunity shifts by pair

V4 net settlement



Two pools still execute; intermediate token movement may be netted.

Settlement can diverge from route use

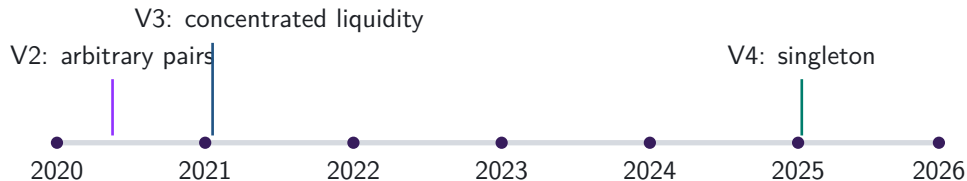
Architecture feasible rules

Exposure realised pool and route use

Calendar date timing only

The route sample and architecture supplement answer different questions

DATA



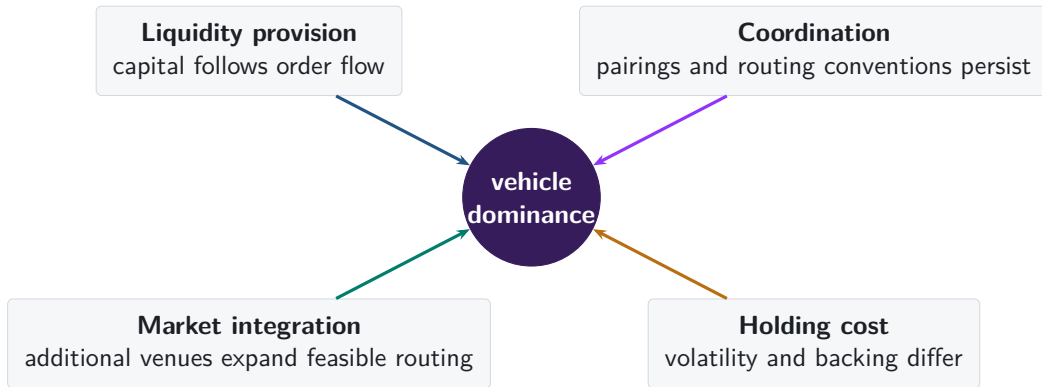
Main route sample

Swap legs from multiple protocols are linked within each transaction. A leg may come from a two-asset pool or from one asset pair inside a multi-asset Curve or Balancer pool.

V1/V2 architecture supplement

Uniswap V1 forced-ETH paths and V2 pair formation are analysed separately. They answer protocol-design questions and do not define the main route perimeter.

Why might one asset become the dominant vehicle?



Native-asset pairing persists after it becomes optional

V1: PROTOCOL RULE



**217,003 token-to-token trades
pass through ETH**

Every token pool pairs with ETH, so the architecture imposes the vehicle.

V2: MARKET CHOICE

95.5%

of single-leg V2 trades use a WETH pool in 2026

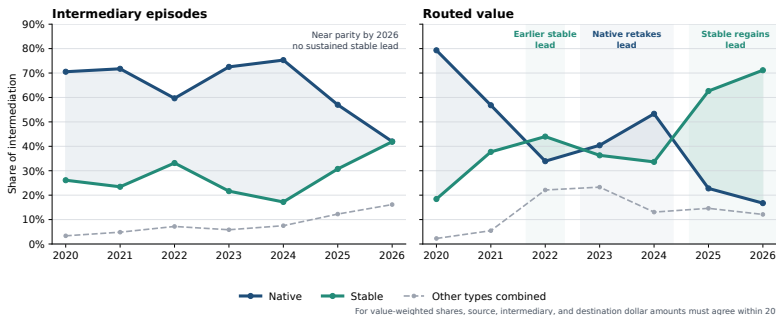
97.9%

of pairs first traded in 2026 include WETH

V2 converted ETH pairing from a protocol rule into a market choice. Native-asset concentration remained high through pair formation and realised trading.

Note: V1 counts linked token-to-ETH and ETH-to-token swaps with matching ETH quantities in one transaction. V2 shares use single-leg Uniswap V2 trades and newly traded pairs; they describe that venue rather than market-wide vehicle dominance.

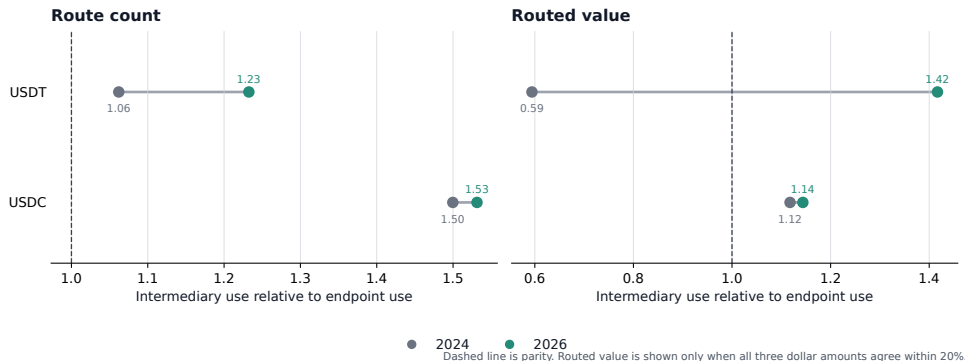
Stablecoins regain the lead in routed value



The aggregate share moves because the network of traded pairs reorganises around stablecoins. Holding the source–destination pair, the calendar date, and the route scope fixed, stablecoin share changes by +0.2 pp (SE 0.8 pp) by count and −1.3 pp (SE 2.2 pp) by value.

Note: The route universe is exact two-leg routes with an observed intermediary. The left panel counts one intermediary episode per route and divides each asset type's episodes by all intermediary episodes. The right panel divides each type's routed value by total routed value among routes whose source, intermediary, and destination dollar amounts agree within 20%. The 2026 observation covers January–June; Other combines imported, liquid-staking, and residual assets. Matched-market estimates weight by route count or value and cluster by ordered pair and calendar date.

USDT drives the rise in stablecoin intermediation



USDT crosses parity by routed value and extends its count advantage; USDC changes little.

Note: Excess use is intermediary share divided by endpoint share on the same route perimeter. The comparison uses native assets, USDC, and USDT and the same January–June dates in 2024 and 2026. Descriptive accounting: see Appendix A9; the identity carries no sampling interval.

WETH-linked trading pairs account for most of the count rotation

WETH

WETH is the source or destination

WETH cannot also be the intermediary; stable share is mechanically 100%.

All matched trading-pair groups

+21.1 pp

95% CI [+18.2 pp, +24.0 pp]

WETH-linked route-count mass: 26.6% → 46.8%

→
exclude
WETH
endpoints

Trading-pair groups without WETH endpoints

+3.7 pp

95% CI [+2.3 pp, +5.2 pp]

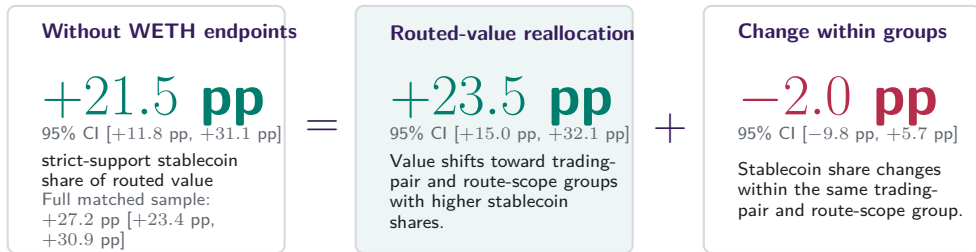
79,347 matched groups

Within the same trading pair, calendar position, and route scope: all groups +0.2 pp [−1.3 pp, +1.7 pp]; without WETH endpoints +0.3 pp [−1.9 pp, +2.6 pp].

The count increase falls from +21.1 pp to +3.7 pp without WETH endpoints. A WETH-linked pair admits only a stablecoin intermediary in this comparison, so the count rotation largely records where trading happens rather than which intermediary a given trade selects.

Note: Exact two-leg native-WETH-versus-stablecoin routes on 181 common month-days. Intervals use 30-day Newey–West covariance on 362 endpoint-year daily observations; 2025 is excluded and actual dates preserve the gap. Within-group WLS fixes the trading pair,

The routed-value rotation extends beyond WETH-linked trading pairs



Exact midpoint identity on each of 181 common calendar days; 2024 versus January–June 2026.

After removing WETH endpoints, value moves toward trading-pair and route-scope groups in which stablecoins already carry more intermediation. The change within those groups is small and imprecise.

Note: Routed value requires source, intermediary, and destination dollar amounts to agree within 20%. The daily midpoint identity is exact. Intervals use the same endpoint-year calendar-HAC covariance as the preceding frame; paired-month-day and bandwidth sensitivities remain in the source. Mukhin (2022), Gopinath and Stein (2021), and Carletti et al. (2021) guide the composition framing, not identification.

Three margins move an aggregate vehicle share

1 Used more often within a pair

USDC → WBTC trades in both years

Stablecoin share of its intermediary use

10.5% → 35.9%

Adds +0.05 pp to the aggregate

Margin total: -0.1 pp

2 Trading moves toward pairs that already use it

USDT → WETH, stablecoin-routed in both years

Share of all routed activity

0.36% → 4.52%

7,447 routes become 54,112; adds +2.17 pp

Margin total: +8.6 pp

3 Newly traded pairs route through it

USDS → WETH, absent from the base year

Routes observed

0 → 3,390

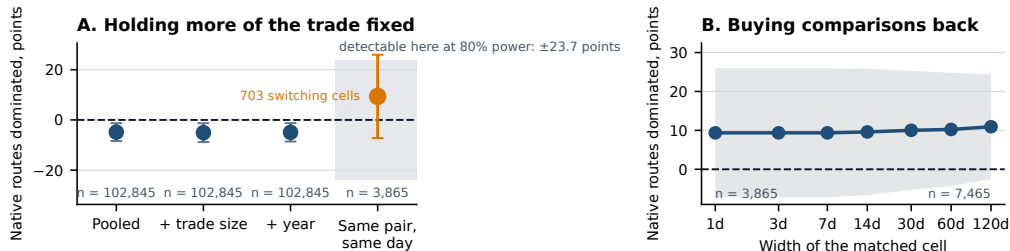
All stablecoin-intermediated; adds +0.13 pp

Margin total: +21.0 pp

The first margin is the one vehicle-currency theory describes, and it did not move. The third nets to +17.8 pp because 48.0% of routes run on pairs alive in only one year: the arrivals route 43.8% through a stablecoin against 6.8% for the ones they replaced. But 65.9% of that gap is what the arrivals are, not how they route: 28.9% of arriving activity is wrapped-ether-paired against 5.2% of departing. Corridors with no vehicle to choose carry 73.3% of the second by count but 42.6% by value; by value most of both runs through corridors with a dollar at an endpoint.

Note: Pooled route-count share among native and stablecoin intermediaries, 2024 against 2026 on 181 common calendar days. Each panel names the largest contributing ordered pair with two canonical symbols; unlabelled assets carry most of the third margin, so a named example is smaller than its total. Contributions are an exact allocation of the aggregate change and are descriptive.

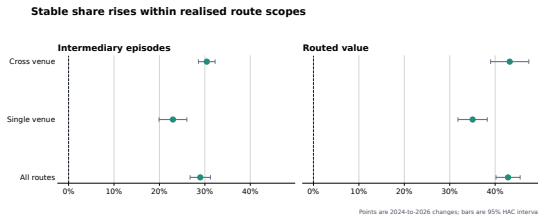
Holding the trade fixed dissolves the intermediary gap



Was a trade carried by the native asset less often dominated by a direct pool it could have used? Pooled, yes: -4.9 points (SE 1.82 points) over 102,845 routes. Between the same two tokens on the same day it is +9.4 points (SE 8.47 points) on 703 switching cells – not distinguishable from zero, in a design that could only have detected 23.7 points or more, and the price-gap outcome agrees on those cells (+186 bps, SE 106 bps). Two questions, one answer: the rotation is where trading happens, not which intermediary a comparable trade selects.

Note: Dominance quality is a separate measure from the aggregate vehicle share and the two are never combined. The outcome indicates that the executed route was dominated by an available direct pool; the price-gap outcome is the same comparison in basis points. Bars are 95% intervals clustered on the ordered pair. Shading is what the strictest column could have detected at 80% power, not a confidence region.

Stablecoin use rises within each venue scope

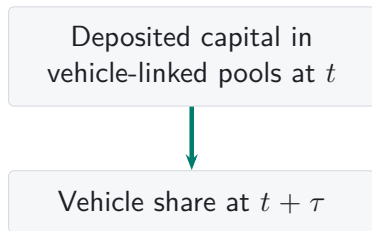


The increase appears within both realised route scopes, so the single- versus cross-venue mix cannot account for the aggregate rotation. Path length does not absorb it: two-leg routes gain +25.4 pp by count (SE 1.05 pp) and longer routes +16.3 pp (SE 1.86 pp), and every venue-scope by path-length cell rises, the weakest by +17.0 pp (SE 1.36 pp). Nor does the pricing rule: among routes priced entirely by the constant-product invariant, 84.8% of 2026 episodes, stablecoin excess use rises from 0.78 to 1.33, and all-Curve routes carry none. Nor does automated path search: intermediation incidence never rises by more than +0.8 pp at 3 public router releases, though cross-exchange reach widens. Every scope here is realised, not assigned; none identifies an effect of integration, routing software, pricing technology, or architecture.

Note: Changes compare the same January–June dates in 2024 and 2026. Bars show 95% calendar-HAC confidence intervals. Excess-use ratios are annual and span the full sample calendar.

Deposited capital neither leads vehicle use nor follows it

LIQUIDITY FIRST

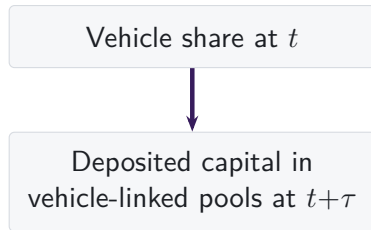


A one log-point higher capital stock predicts a next-day episode-share change of 0.00 pp (SE 0.04 pp); at thirty days -0.64 pp (SE 0.26 pp).

No use/capital measure pair is positive in both directions at any two of the one-, seven-, and thirty-day horizons; the smallest Holm-adjusted p is 0.17. The only strong longer-horizon pattern runs the other way: over the following 120 days, higher-capital pool-days lose episode share (-2.21 pp per log point, SE 0.39 pp).

Note: Daily panel of the five vehicle candidates on the full 2,238-day V2 calendar with candidate and date fixed effects; standard errors use 30-day calendar HAC on date-aggregated scores, and Holm adjustment is within direction; a month-block bootstrap and candidate-date clustering agree. Deposited capital is a reserve stock; provider flows and concentrated-liquidity depth are measured separately. Predictive associations only, not causal feedback.

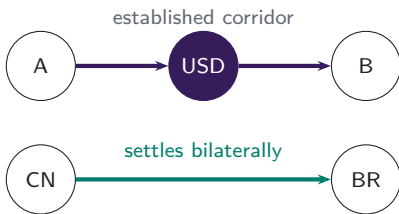
VEHICLE USE FIRST



A one-point higher episode share predicts a next-day capital change of -0.03% (SE 0.03%); at thirty days -0.32% (SE 0.27%).

The same arithmetic governs any aggregate currency share

A FAMILIAR SETTING



China and Brazil have built clearing arrangements for settling their bilateral trade in renminbi. The established corridor above is unaffected.

THE SHARE CAN FALL WITH NO CORRIDOR SWITCHING

A currency's share of all settled trade falls when trade grows fastest along corridors that never adopted it, even if every corridor that uses it today keeps using it tomorrow.

Margin 2 is trade reallocating toward corridors that already avoid the incumbent.

Margin 3 is a corridor that had no meaningful volume opening on other terms.

Our routes measure the same two margins directly, because the transaction log records the whole path rather than its legs.

Note: Illustrative comparison only. Renminbi clearing arrangements in Brazil follow the memorandum of understanding between the People's Bank of China and the Banco Central do Brasil. No currency share of trade settlement is measured here, and no causal or policy claim is made about either setting.

The market changed, not the trade

SHARE OF INTERMEDIATION CARRIED BY STABLECOINS

as the comparison holds more of the market fixed



Stablecoins won the market, not the trade: the rotation is where trading moved, not which intermediary a comparable trade chose.

The three shares on the left are one measure at three levels of conditioning and are directly comparable. The estimate on the right is a different measure on a different sample and is not on that scale; it is shown because an independent design reaches the same reading. Neither is an entry or exit effect, and neither identifies a treatment.

Appendix map

Definitions and data

- A1 Route units and vehicle status
- A2 Asset types and backing regimes
- A3 Sample construction and exclusions

Reconstruction and validation

- A4 Exact transaction state
- A5 Protocol-specific state
- A6 Forced routes in V1

Robustness

- A7 Daily and weekly frequencies
- A8 Count and value weighting
- A9 Observed route endpoints

Mechanisms

- A10 Capital, inventory, and depth
- A11 Coordination and integration
- A12–A13 References

A1. One reconstructed route is one unit



one route unit
two swap legs

- Each linked $i \rightarrow k \rightarrow o$ route is counted once.
- Asset k is classified as the intermediary on that route.
- Dominance is the share of route units or supported value carried by k .

How we reconstruct a route from one transaction

Direct swap

one transaction



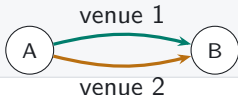
Sequential vehicle route

one transaction



Parallel split

one transaction



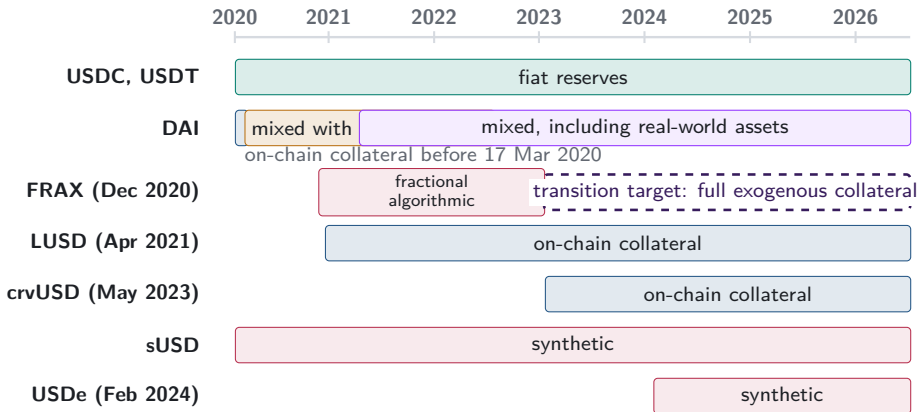
Round trip

one transaction



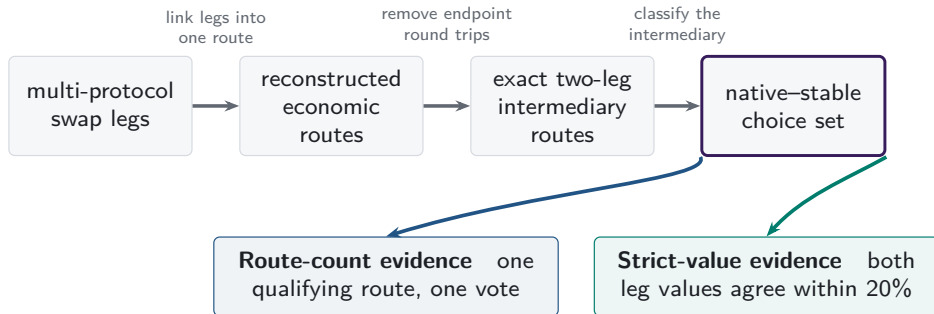
Vehicle choice directs indirect order flow toward particular assets and pools. Transaction-level paths reveal that choice rather than leaving it inside aggregate turnover.

A2. Stablecoin backing cannot be treated as fixed



Note: Bars begin at public launch or the sample start for older tokens. DAI's dated regimes follow the Maker Governance actions that added USDC-A and activated RWA001-A. FRAX's dashed arrow follows FIP-188 and denotes a target, not observed collateral.

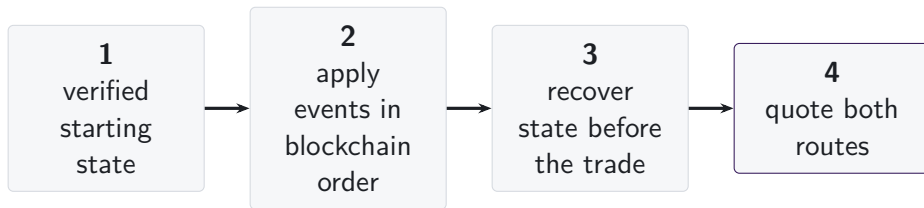
A3. One route universe supports two measurements



Box widths do not represent attrition.

The route sample links legs across protocols; one asset pair inside a multi-asset Curve or Balancer pool may supply a leg. The V1/V2 architecture evidence is separate. Dollar support affects value weighting, not route inclusion.

A4. State is reconstructed immediately before execution



- Pool events are applied in blockchain order from a verified starting state.
- Each route is quoted using the pool state immediately before the transaction.
- Missing state intervals are excluded, and their share of trading volume is reported.

A5. Each AMM family has a different state vector

	reserves or active liquidity	ticks	amplification	weights or scaling	rates or oracles	fees	hooks
Constant product	■	—	—	—	—	■	—
Concentrated liquidity	■	■	—	—	—	■	—
StableSwap families	■	—	■	—	■	■	—
Weighted pools	■	—	—	■	■	■	—
V4 singleton	■	■	—	—	—	■	□

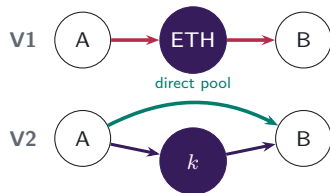
The common object is the state immediately before execution.
The fields required to recover that state vary with the pricing rule.

■ required state

□ hooks outside comparison

Protocol design changes markets, depth, and settlement

V1 → V2: PAIR CREATION



V1 admits only ETH-token pools. V2 permits any ERC-20 pair, so market creation determines whether direct and vehicle paths coexist.

Which edges exist?

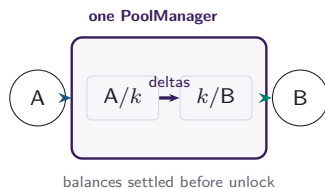
V3: ACTIVE LIQUIDITY



LPs choose a price range and fee tier for each pool. Positions covering the current price determine active liquidity in the direct pair and in each vehicle spoke.

Which path offers depth at this size?

V4: SHARED ACCOUNTING



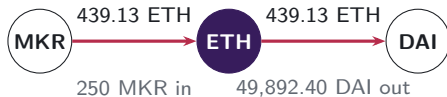
One PoolManager holds all pools. During a lock, the two swaps update balance deltas; the caller settles its obligations before the lock ends.

Where is the route settled?

Economic implication. Pair creation changes available paths; concentrated liquidity changes pair-specific execution at the current state and trade size; the singleton changes the settlement boundary for a route that still uses two pools.

A6. V1 forced routes have an on-chain signature

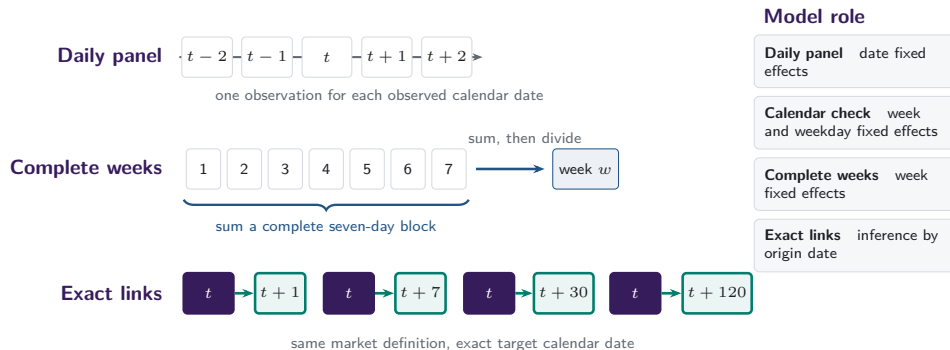
- Token-to-token execution emits two linked swaps through ETH.
- Matching ETH quantities distinguish protocol-imposed intermediation from unrelated bundled swaps.
- 129,810 mandate-era token-to-token transactions carry exactly matching ETH legs; the trace shows the largest.



same transaction, matching ETH flow

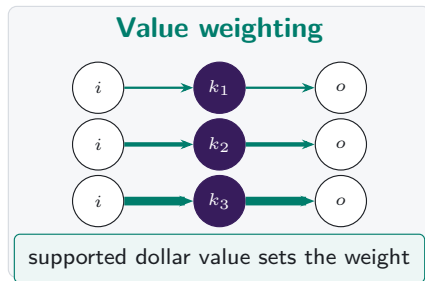
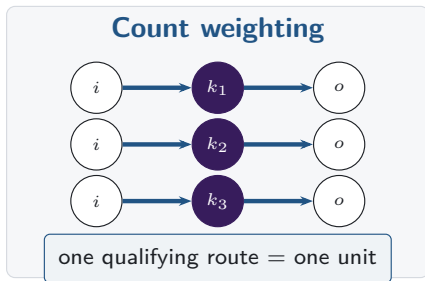
Note: Both legs of transaction 0x4dca160d...96a0ca16 (15 March 2020, block 9,674,728) report the same ETH amount to the last recorded digit.

A7. Daily and weekly frequencies answer different questions



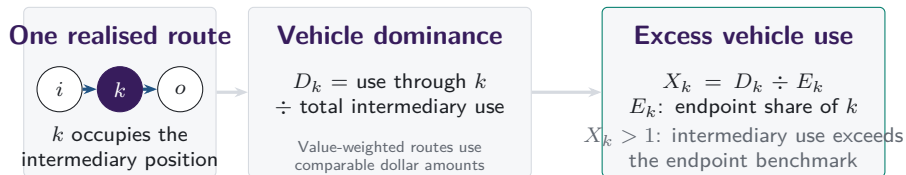
Missing target dates remain missing: row shifts and calendar months do not substitute for exact calendar links.

A8. Count versus value weighting

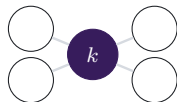


Note: Both panels contain the same routes. Line widths are illustrative, and value weighting applies only on the stated valuation-support band.

Vehicle dominance aggregates realised intermediary choices

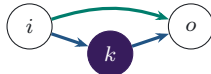


Separate characteristics of the asset and route set



Network position

position of k in the feasible graph



Execution cost

which route returns more at the same state

Observed route-endpoint use supplies the benchmark; network position and same-state route costs remain separate characteristics.

A9. Intermediary and route-endpoint use are separate

Intermediary share

$$I_{k,t}^N = \frac{n_{k,t}^I}{\sum_j n_{j,t}^I}$$

How often asset k sits inside a route.

Endpoint share

$$E_{k,t}^N = \frac{n_{k,t}^E}{\sum_j n_{j,t}^E}$$

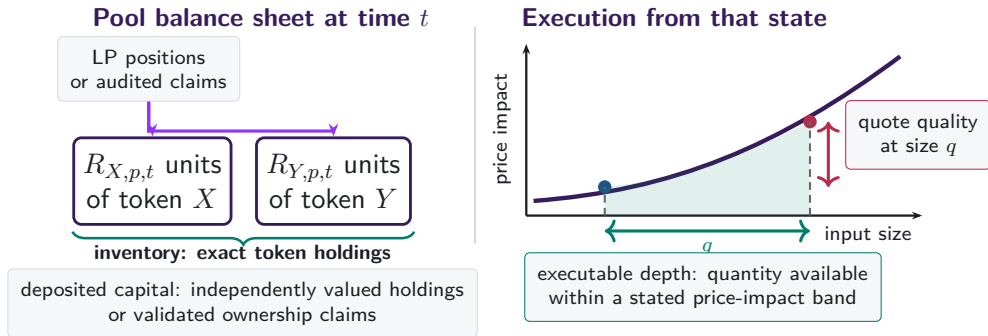
How often asset k appears at either end of the observed pool route.

The benchmark describes reconstructed pool routes; an aggregator instruction can begin or end outside the connected component.

Excess use compares intermediation with observed route-endpoint use on the same support.

Note: For USDT in 2024–26, within-category changes account for 93.7% of the count change and 85.6% of the routed-value change; reweighting between single- and cross-venue categories accounts for 6.3% and 14.4%. The identity carries no sampling interval.

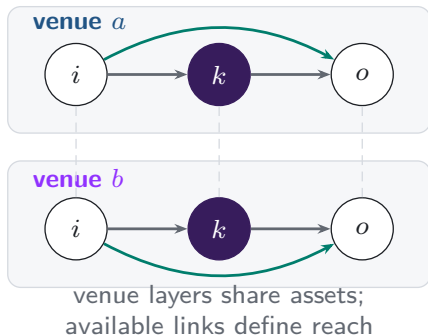
A10. Capital, inventory, and depth are different objects



Capital is a stock. Depth and quotes depend on trade size and current pool state.

A11. Additional venues expand the feasible route set

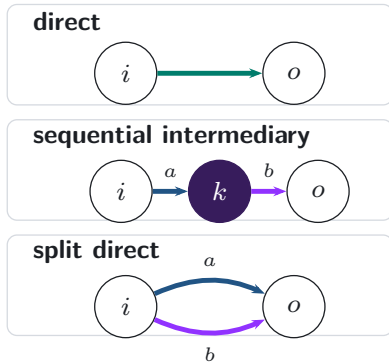
Feasible venue layers



realised
execution

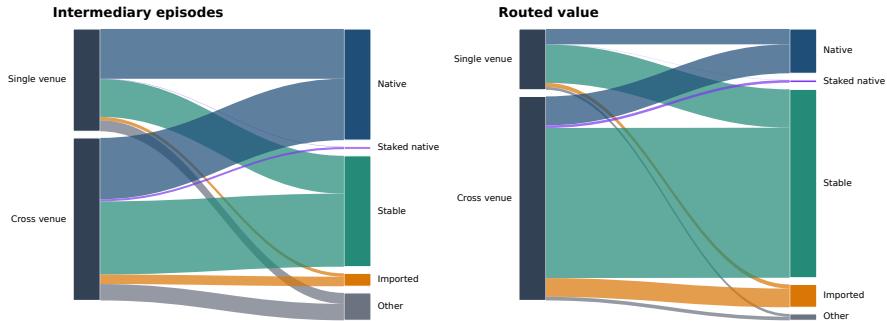


Realised route topology



A11b. Venue scope and vehicle type differ in 2026

Integration and vehicle composition are separate margins in 2026



Ribbon width is the share of 2026 intermediation jointly classified by venue scope and intermediary type.

Note: Ribbon width is the share of 2026 intermediation jointly classified by venue scope and intermediary type.

A12. References: vehicle currencies and market structure

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A13. References: decentralised exchange design

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